

5 Foundation Movements

Coaching cues for each pattern | Lisa McPherson, CPT

These five patterns are the backbone of the 4-Week Training Foundations program. Master the cues below and every exercise in the course will feel like a natural extension of what you already know. The full Day A workout — warmup through cooldown — is on the next pages.

01 The Hip Hinge

HIP-DOMINANT

The single most important movement you will learn, and the one most responsible for back injuries when done wrong. Power comes from your hips, not your lower back.

KEY CUES

- > Push the wall behind you with your hips — forces the hinge without overthinking.
- > Soft bend in the knees, not a squat. Knees unlock but do not drive forward.
- > Pack your shoulders. Blades slightly down and back before you move.
- > Keep the weight close — drag it up your legs, do not let it float away.

Watch for: if your lower back rounds at the bottom, the weight is too heavy.

02 The Squat

KNEE-DOMINANT

Start with the goblet squat — the safest way to learn the pattern before any barbell. The counterbalance keeps the torso upright and teaches you what proper position feels like.

KEY CUES

- > Knees track over your second toe — follow the feet, don't collapse inward.
 - > Chest up, proud posture — keeps torso upright through the movement.
 - > Sit between your heels, not behind them — weight across your whole foot.
 - > Spread the floor with your feet — keeps knees stable, glutes switched on.
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03 The Push

HORIZONTAL PRESS

Pressing builds chest, shoulders, and triceps. Poor mechanics build up quietly until they become a real shoulder problem. Get it right early.

KEY CUES

- > Elbows at 45 degrees — not tucked all the way in, not flared straight out.
 - > Shoulder blades together and down before you lower — not after.
 - > Drive feet into the floor — full body tension makes the press stronger.
 - > Control the descent — 2 to 3 seconds down, then press with intent.
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04 The Pull

UPPER-BODY ROW

Most people press far more than they pull. Over time that builds a real imbalance. A strong back directly protects your spine. Match every push with a pull.

KEY CUES

- > Pull elbows to your back pockets — activates the lats, stops the shrug.
 - > Shoulders down before you pull — set the position first, then go.
 - > Squeeze at the end — fully contract the back at the top of every rep.
 - > Control the return — lower slowly, do not let it drop.
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05 The Brace & Carry

CORE STABILITY

Your core's real job is to resist movement, not create it. Crunches miss the point. Every squat, hinge, and press needs your core bracing to protect your spine.

KEY CUES

- > 360-degree brace — breathe into your belly, create pressure all around.
- > Ribs down — stops your lower back from overarching.
- > Tall spine — string pulling the crown of your head toward the ceiling.
- > Brace before you move — not halfway through the rep.

Lower Body Strength

Complete session: warmup · main workout · cooldown | ~50–60 minutes total

WARM-UP		~10 min
90/90 Hip Mobility Stretch	Opens hip rotation before loading. Tight hips mean your lower back compensates. Cue: Move slowly between sides. Breathe into the stretch. Don't force the range.	8–10 reps per side
Cat-Cow	Wakes up spinal mobility and gets the lower back ready. Cue: Inhale to extend, exhale to round. Slow and deliberate.	10 reps
World's Greatest Stretch	Opens hips, thoracic spine, and hamstrings in one movement. Cue: Move through every position with control. Your range doesn't need to match a video.	5 reps per side
Glute Bridge (Activation)	Gets the glutes firing before the hip thrust session. Cue: Squeeze hard at the top, hold 1 sec. Drive through heels. Ribs down.	1 set × 15 reps
Lateral Band Walk	Activates the glute medius — keeps knees tracking correctly under load. Cue: Light band. Slight squat the whole time. Feet parallel. Control every step.	1 set × 15 steps each way
Leg Swing Front to Back	Dynamic hip flexor and hamstring mobility through the range you're about to use. Cue: Hold a wall. Start small, gradually increase range. Controlled swing.	10 reps per side
Lateral Lunge	Opens hips in the frontal plane — a direction most warmups miss completely. Cue: Hips back as you lower. Knee over toes. Only as deep as you can control.	8 reps per side

MAIN WORKOUT ~35–40 MIN	
Sets x Reps. Rest 90–120 sec between sets on compound movements. Last few reps should feel hard. Log your weights so you can push heavier next time.	
Hip Thrust	3 × 10–12 2 min
Start with a dumbbell. Squeeze glutes hard at the top — hold 1 second. > Drive through heels. Ribs down. Chin tucked. No lower back arch.	
Romanian Deadlift	3 × 10 2 min
Push hips back, not hands down. Stop before your lower back rounds. > Keep the dumbbells dragging close to your legs. Pause and feel the stretch at the bottom.	
Reverse Lunge	3 × 10 per side 90 sec
Step back, not forward. Front knee over toes. Back knee hovers above the floor. > Weight in the front leg. Drive through the front heel to stand.	
Goblet Squat	3 × 10 2 min
Dumbbell at chest. The counterbalance teaches upright torso position. > Knees out gently as you lower. Only as deep as you can keep your chest lifted.	
Dead Bug	3 × 8 per side 60 sec
Lower back flat to the floor before you start. The moment it lifts, you've gone too far.	

> Exhale fully as you extend. Reduce range if you can't keep your back flat.

Farmer's Carry

2 × 20–30 m

90 sec

Heavy dumbbells, tall spine, walk with intention. Harder than it looks.

> Shoulders back and down. Brace your core the whole time. If posture falls apart, lighter weight.

COOL-DOWN

~5 min

Kneeling Hip Flexor Stretch

30 sec per side

Tight after any lower body session. Skip this and your lower back pays for it.

| Cue: Tuck pelvis slightly to deepen. Stay tall, no lower back arch. Breathe slowly.

90/90 Hamstring Stretch

30 sec per side

Closes the loop on all the hip hinge and RDL work.

| Cue: Hold behind your thigh, not the knee. Soft bend in the leg. Stretch, not pain.

Figure 4 Stretch

30 sec per side

Targets deep glute and piriformis — places a foam roller misses.

| Cue: Flex the crossed foot to protect your knee. Gently pull the opposite leg toward you.

Child's Pose

30 sec

Every session ends here. Decompresses the spine, slows breathing, closes the session.

| Cue: Reach arms forward, chest sinks, breathe into your lower back. Nowhere to be.

The Full 4-Week Program

3 days per week | 45–60 min per session | Warmup and cooldown included in every day

The program runs three days per week with at least one rest day between sessions. Each day has its own warmup and cooldown built in — those are part of the program, not optional add-ons. Below is the complete structure for all three days.

DAY A

Lower Body Strength

Glutes · Legs · Stability · Core

Full warmup and cooldown shown above.

- > Hip Thrust — 3 × 10–12
- > Romanian Deadlift — 3 × 10
- > Reverse Lunge — 3 × 10 per side
- > Goblet Squat — 3 × 10
- > Dead Bug — 3 × 8 per side
- > Farmer's Carry — 2 × 20–30 m

DAY B

Upper Body Strength

Pressing · Pulling · Posture · Shoulder stability

Includes warmup (Cat-Cow, Thoracic Rotation, World's Greatest, Arm Circles, Band Pull-Apart, YTW Raise) and cooldown (Open Book, Band Lat Stretch, Thread the Needle, Triceps Stretch).

- > DB Bench Press or Push-Up — 3 × 10
- > Band-Assisted Pull-Up or Lat Pulldown — 3 × 8
- > Overhead Press — 3 × 10
- > Chest Supported Row — 3 × 12
- > Dumbbell Curl + Tricep Extension (superset) — 3 rounds
- > Pallof Press — 3 × 10 per side

DAY C

Integration & Core

Movement quality · Single-leg stability · Core control

Lighter loading. Reinforce patterns and build stability. Includes own warmup and cooldown.

- > Single-Leg Glute Bridge — 3 × 10 per side
- > Reverse Lunge — 3 × 10 per side
- > Push-Up + Inverted Row (superset) — 3 rounds
- > Monster Walk + Hip Abduction (superset) — 3 rounds
- > Dead Bug + Copenhagen Plank (superset) — 2 rounds
- > Stir-the-Pot — 2 × 8 each direction

WEEKS 3 & 4 — PROGRESSIVE OVERLOAD

The program structure stays the same across all 4 weeks. What changes is the demand. On every exercise where you completed all sets and reps with clean form in Weeks 1 and 2, add a small amount of weight — usually one dumbbell size up. For bodyweight exercises like the dead bug and push-up, add 2–3 reps per set instead.

If your form broke down anywhere, stay at the same weight in Weeks 3 and 4. Movement quality always comes before load. The weight will come.

This guide is a real piece of the course. In the full 4-Week Training Foundations program, every exercise above has a coaching video, you log your weights directly into a built-in tracker, and progressive overload is structured in so you always know your next step.

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